



Artificial Wood

Scientists have synthesized a Bioinspired Polymeric Wood that is water and fire resistant.
<https://digit.in/nov18-63-1>



Blockchain Phone by HTC

HTC has launched Exodus 1, its blockchain focused phone which can only be bought with cryptocurrency.
<https://digit.in/nov18-63-2>

Drones Suck

While almost everyone is going ga-ga over drones. I am not.

Boo-Man | boo@digit.in

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s soon as word of new drone regulations coming out reached us, I knew we were going to be inundated

with stories about them. It's pretty natural for this to happen in the tech world, and Digit is no exception to the rule. While it's one thing to have this happen for a new phone or gadget, or even technology, when it comes to drones in India, there are more questions than there are answers as far as I'm concerned.

My first problem is with the word itself. In common parlance, there is a word that better communicates what people mean when they say the word drone – this word is “quadcopter”. If you look at our cover, you will see a quadcopter on it, and that's pretty much the general public's understanding of the term. Despite knowing better, even we've had to toe the popular line, because it's more important for all of you to see the issue on stands and know it's about drones than to try and teach you the difference between quadcopters and drones using a cover... I digress though.

There is nothing new about drones. Unmanned aerial vehicles have been around for a long time. In fact, we've had flying miniatures that run on fuel for ages now. It's only modern electronics that has enabled us to bring weights of UAVs down and use electric motors to fly. Fundamentally though, nothing much has changed. Of course drone companies

don't want you to think of their pride and joy as just another remote controlled flier, so they tack on more and more tech, which then requires just the right regulations to be passed, and things get insanely complex.

It's why we have so many castles in the sky right now. Companies painting rosy pictures of AI run drones delivering stuff to you wherever you are – even while you're driving on a highway! Then there are flying taxi services, medical emergency drones that can bring people the organs they've been waiting for when a donor dies, or antivenom for the snakebite you just received (only our Ed has to worry about that, because he's in the land where



So excite

everything tries to kill you). If you can dream it, a drone can do it. Or so they will have you believe. Not going to happen in a hurry. There's tonnes of rules and regulations and safety precautions to account for, and as much as we like to believe it, AI really isn't that advanced yet. Besides, battery capacity is limited as well, and commercial drones aren't able to fly as far as we'd like them to... certainly not flying taxis!

Then there is the ugly side to drones. Miniatures are being used to invade the privacy of celebrities. You're next, of course, as soon as everyone is tired of

looking at naked celebs, they're going to get drones themselves to spy on the neighbours. I'm too ugly for it to affect me, but surely some of you still value privacy... And if something exists, people are going to find ways to misuse it. If it can deliver packages, it can deliver drugs... then of course there are just the trolls and the scum of the internet to consider. We've already got rotos attached to dead animals to make some really morbid looking drones. Why? Because if it's possible, it's probably being done in this crazy age we live in.

If despite all of the challenges, drones (quadcopters, really) become as mainstream as companies promise, do you really think that will be utopia as they make it out to be? Remember, the brochure always looks better than reality. Imagine millions of little electric motors going “bzzzzzzz” above your heads, all the time... it might just drive you insane!

I get it. We like tech, and we love AI, and we love gadgets and new things. However, new is not necessarily better. We seem to be in such a rush to replace ourselves with tech – taxi and Uber drivers, delivery people, photographers, pilots; we want to replace them all. We assume that machines will do these jobs better, and they very well might, but at what cost? Then again, maybe you think I'm just being a sentimental fool – afraid of change and wishing for the good old days. Maybe you're right... but what if you're wrong? 